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Eddie Bert

Trombonist Eddie Bert was born in Yonkers, New York on May 16, 1922. He was inspired by early recordings of Lester Young and took lessons from Basie trombonist Benny Morton. He has played with a lengthy list of top big bands, including ensembles led by Benny Goodman, Stan Kenton and Woody Herman. Eddie has played on numerous recordings, including historical LPs by Charles Mingus, Thad Jones and Thelonious Monk. He continues to compose and perform as he enters his sixth decade as a professional musician.

Eddie was interviewed in Danbury, Connecticut on November 20, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Danbury, Connecticut. I'm very pleased to have veteran trombonist Eddie Bert with me. Thank you very much for joining me.

EB: Thanks for having me.

MR: I barely know where to start with a career like yours, but it's very impressive to look at the people that have played with you and the people you have played with. But maybe we'll just talk, we'll go backwards for a moment. Tell me what you're doing right now with Bobby Short. It sounds great.

EB: Well I'm at the Carlyle and he added three saxes, two trumpets and a trombone about five years ago. So I do that, among other things.

MR: This would be your — let me do the math here — 50— how long — I can't do the math — how many years have you been playing the trombone?

EB: Well I started when I was 13, so it's quite a while.

MR: Yeah. Long time. Did you come from a musical background, your family?

EB: No.

MR: No?

EB: No.

MR: What made you gravitate — and was trombone your first instrument?

EB: Not really. You see I grew up in the Bronx. Then when I was ten I moved to Mount Vernon. And in the Bronx they didn't have any band so I didn't know where that radio, the radio stuff came from. I heard the radio and I heard music but I didn't know anything about it. So then when I got to Mount Vernon they had a band in the school, in the elementary school. And the teacher said, "here, try this trumpet." So I played the trumpet. And she said yeah, you'd be a good trumpet player, tell your father to get you a horn. Nothing. So I had to take what was there. And they had an E flat alto horn. And you don't do too much with that. When the tuba goes oomph, you go pah. Oomph-pah, oomph-pah,

oomph. And that got kind of boring. So one day we were playing a concert in one of the schools and we were playing the "Skater's Waltz," and the drummer couldn't play three-four. So I said let me play that. Because I had some friends in the drum section you know. So anyway I started playing bass drum and we were right in back of the trombones. And they had these counter melodies in the marches and stuff like that. And I said yeah, I like that. So I had a broken umbrella. And, you know the part that goes up? So I did that, and I had a razzer. You know what a razzer is?

MR: I think so.

EB: One of those big rubber things brrumph, brrumpt, brrumph. So I'd walk down the street going like that. So finally my father says what are you doing? I says playing trombone. But it isn't a trombone. I said yeah but I don't have one. So he finally got me one of these stupid, it was like what we call a pea shooter. It was made by Wurlitzer. And it was a terrible horn but it was a horn. So I played it for a little bit.

MR: It was a trombone but just a lousy one?

EB: Yeah. But then after about a year he bought me a horn. So that's how I started.

MR: That's a great story. Wouldn't it be cool to have a picture of you going down the street with that umbrella. You know it's funny too, a lot of guys, did you say it was a Sears trombone?

EB: No a Wurlitzer.

MR: Wurlitzer, okay.

EB: They made pianos but I guess they made a few instruments.

MR: Yeah that's true.

EB: It was like Sears & Roebuck.

MR: Sure. A lot of those early instruments came from them, and the catalogue, and cost five or six dollars.

EB: Yeah.

MR: That's cool. So you had mentioned hearing the music on the radio.

EB: Yeah.

MR: Was there particular things that started to catch your ear at those times?

EB: No but my cousin had a band. He was a trumpet player. One of my cousins. And he said do you want to play with my band, because he heard me practicing. And I said yeah. Because in those days you couldn't play jazz in the school. They said that's not music so you can't play that. So we had to go to people's houses. Guys would get together and we'd get what's called stock arrangements, and we'd play them. So he had a band so I went with him and started playing these stocks. But in those days you could go in the record store and they had 78s. And they had booths that you could listen to records. So I got this record, Jones-Smith Incorporated. I didn't know what it was but I liked the tenor

player. So I had no idea who it was. But then I found out it was Lester Young and that they were going in The Famous Door.

MR: Jones and Smith?

EB: Jones-Smith. It was Jo Jones and Carl Smith.

MR: And who Smith?

EB: Carl Smith. Because the situation was that Basie had signed with Decca and they were on their way to New York to record. And they stopped by Chicago and this guy from Vocalion Records wanted them to record. But he couldn't record because he had a contract, so they used the name Jones-Smith Incorporated. But it was actually Basie's rhythm section with Lester and this guy Carl "Tatti" Smith on trumpet and James Rushing singing. And they made four sides. And that was Lester Young's debut on records. And I had to hear him. I mean you know, I said I've got to hear this guy, he sounded great. Because the tenor is in the same register as the trombone. So the way I got to see him was the band was playing at The Famous Door. I couldn't get in because I was too young. They wouldn't let kids in. So I knew they were rehearsing for a record date so I called Benny Morton and I said would you mind giving me lessons? So he said, the only way I could do that, you're going to have to come to rehearsal and I'll teach you after rehearsal. Perfect. I got to meet Lester and all the guys in the band.

MR: Oh that's great.

EB: And I knew them like all my life.

MR: That would have been —

EB: That was August of '38.

MR: '38. Yeah. That was their New York debut, wasn't it?

EB: Yeah well the rehearsal I went to they were rehearsing "Stop Beating Around Mulberry Bush," "London Bridge," and "Jumpin' at the Woodside," which was a head arrangement, they didn't have any arrangement for that you know.

MR: God, what a moment.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: And the trombone section, was Benny —

EB: Dickie Wells and Dan Minor. But Benny was like a studious guy and I knew that he would be receptive. Dickie was kind of wild in those days. I got to know Dickie later. And Dan Minor was a great guy too, but Benny had that style and he was always practicing, I could tell. So he was good.

MR: And what did your father think of that?

EB: He didn't know what was going on really. He was a baseball player and he wanted me to play baseball so he was a catcher and he bought the mask and the protection and anyway, he later on became an umpire.

MR: Really.

EB: So I had to go put the score up, so I used to bring my horn and in between innings practice behind the scoreboard.

MR: That's great.

EB: When I went with Charlie Barnet he finally says, "I guess you're serious."

MR: Yeah. He finally saw that there might be a future in this, huh?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Wow. That wasn't actually your first job was it?

EB: No.

MR: With Barnet?

EB: No.

MR: So you started, let's see, you got through high school playing in the school bands and stuff, right? And then it says you went with Sam Donahue? When you were 18?

EB: Well the first band I went with was actually a non-union band. We played at a place called the Post Lodge in Larchmont, New York for about a year, or maybe a year and a half. And what it was, it was three saxes, two trumpets, a trombone and four rhythm. And we played, it was on the style of the Savoy Sultans. And that was seven days a week. And well, I was the only white guy in the band but that's what I wanted to play, with that kind of music. So that's what I did. But it was a non-union band and all that. So then all of a sudden I got this offer from Sam Donahue, so I had to join the union, like in one day and go up to Boston and meet him. That's the way that happened.

MR: Did you have to do anything special to get into the union?

EB: No.

MR: Just pay your dues?

EB: I think they gave me a second trombone part on "Tiger Rag" and see if I could play that.

MR: Yeah?

EB: You know, it was just a formality. But my father knew some violin player that was in the union so he sort of got me in.

MR: Gosh the union played a pretty big role at that time, didn't it?

EB: At that time, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Because you had to — if you wanted to quit a band, didn't you have to give a certain amount of notice?

EB: Yeah. But I didn't have to give any notice because it was a non-union band.

MR: I see.

EB: So that was bypassed.

MR: So by this time you'd pretty much decided this is what I'm going to do.

EB: No, in other words, I liked to play and that was it. In fact, I was making $17 a week with that band and I was going with this girl from when I was 13 we met, only 13. And I said, "we can get married now." So we did. Because I had to go on the road and I wasn't going to leave her, so $17 a week was a lot then.

MR: Oh my. You could send some money home, huh?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Wow. What was it like being on the road? How old were you? You were 18?

EB: 18. Yeah.

MR: Traveled in a bus?

EB: Well mostly buses, yeah, or cars, a lot by car. So eventually I went with Red Norvo. We rehearsed for three months in a place called Odd Fellows Hall, and it was on 48th Street. We rehearsed for three months in that. Guys from Duke's band would come by. Because Red was well known at that time. But this was like, he had a band from Pittsburgh and he had heard me jamming in a place which was across the street from where Sweet Basil's is now. And we used to go in there and jam, it was with a guy, I don't know if you know him, Luther Henderson. It was Luther Henderson, Leonard Ware on guitar, and a bass player, Slim. And everybody used to go in and jam. So Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey came in one night and he said, "I'm starting a band do you want to come with us?" So I said sure. You know, and that's how I got with Red.

MR: Wow. That was your first recorded solo, wasn't it? With him?

EB: Yeah.

MR: "Jersey Bounce."

EB: That's right.

MR: Do you remember that moment? That session?

EB: Well yeah. It was in Liederkranz Hall. And in those days you'd be in the hall, or this recording studio, and they would call downstairs and say, "start the wax." That's where they got that name cutting wax, because I guess the machines were all in the basement and they would cut, you know, the record, and that's how you made a record. So we recorded three vocals that day with Mildred Bailey and "Jersey Bounce." But Red told me later, he had a contract with Columbia and, as you know the war started, and that put a crimp in that. So he never got use of the contract. He would have been a bigger name probably.

MR: Right.

EB: But we did only those four sides.

MR: Do you remember what you got paid for that? You seem to have a pretty good recall.

EB: It was forty-one and a quarter at that time.

MR: Yeah.

EB: That's what scale was. But years later, like maybe 50 years later, somebody gave me a collection from 25 to 45 big bands. And on it, or in it, was this "Jersey Bounce" by Red Norvo. I said well I know what it sounds like. But let's see what they did with the CD. And I played it. It was slower, and I played a whole different solo, because it was slower. So the way I figured it, that one went about 3 minutes and 25 seconds. And in those days you couldn't go beyond 3 minutes. So what must have happened, we made the first take, or one of the first takes, right? And they said it's too long, you've got to shorten it. So we sped it up, you know we played it faster. So that it would be about 3 minutes. So I called Red and I said, "hey, there's another take on 'Jersey Bounce.'" He says, "how did I play?"

MR: Years later. That's great. How did I do.

EB: I never would have known that there was another take except somebody gave me this box.

MR: So they were able to somehow get the slower take on the wax.

EB: Well they can get it on the CD.

MR: Right. But at the time they couldn't put it on a 78.

EB: No they couldn't put it on the 78.

MR: So that master survived or something.

EB: Yeah, it's amazing. Because all the solos were different, because of the tempo.

MR: That's funny, we can't fit it on the thing so speed it up.

EB: But Red had a good band in those days. Eddie Sauter wrote for him and a guy by the name of Johnny Thompson, who was studying with Eddie Sauter. So we had all good arrangements. And he had double reeds, like oboes, bassoons —

MR: Oh my.

EB: Flutes.

MR: So that's where Eddie Sauter got that thing in his head.

EB: Well he had that, because he had worked with Red. You know he was the trumpet player. And he played third trumpet with Red. He said if that would have been fourth he would have played fourth. But he ended up a writer. And he wrote great. But that's how he started with Red.

MR: What about the war years? Did you go in the service?

EB: Well the day after we opened at the Blue Gardens with Red, that was December 6, 1941. So the war started the next day. But we did travel, we traveled in the midwest, did a lot of theaters. And Jimmy Durante was, he did twelve weeks with us. But at that point you couldn't get gas so we had to travel by train. We had our own car — I mean car on the train, you know what I mean?

MR: Sure. A Pullman type?

EB: Yeah. And they'd disconnect us and connect us with another train and all that. So we did a whole bunch of theaters. Mildred did some of them with us. But Jimmy Durante was part of the act, until the draft started getting through to the band. So then Red broke up and wanted to get a small band. So he said I don't have any trumpet player that knows how to play small band, you know in the big band it was different. So I said yeah, I know a guy. And when I was a kid, I played with a band called Hal Gill, who was from Fordham, which wasn't too far from Mount Vernon and in that band I met Shorty Rodgers, Stan Getz, Manny Albam, all these guys were playing in the band. We were all a bunch of kids. So I knew Shorty, and Shorty and I got a group together. We used to rehearse in Mount Vernon and played gigs if we could get any. Nobody would hire us because we didn't have any saxophones. What we had was trumpet, trombone and rhythm. So anyway, Shorty had just gone with Will Bradley. That was his first band. So I called him and I said, "you want to go with Red Norvo with a small band?" "Oh yeah." So I got him on the band.

MR: There you go.

EB: So it was a great band. And I'm trying to get some recordings of that band out. We were two days in George Simon's house recording, because it was a recording ban, in '42. And we were at The Famous Door so we were rehearsed and the band was tight. A good band. Aaron Sachs, Shorty Rodgers, Clyde Lombardi, Specs Powell and Hank Cohoot on piano.

MR: What did the musicians in general think about that recording ban?

EB: We had to go along with it, but that ruined the big band business. Because then vocalists started recording with string sections, recorded in Europe, which they could do, and all of a sudden the vocalists were the big thing.

MR: Yeah. People's tastes changed because that's all they were getting?

EB: Yeah. Before there were singers with bands, like Frank Sinatra, Peggy Lee, they were band singers. And now the band accompanied them. It reversed. So it ruined the big bands.

MR: It's too bad. It lasted almost two years, didn't it?

EB: Yeah. Then there was another one around '47.

MR: Oh. I didn't know about that.

EB: That really did it.

MR: Did you have to go into the Army?

EB: Yeah.

MR: What was your experience like? What did they have you doing?

EB: Well that's when I — I don't want to go into the whole story, but I had my horn with me, and well I don't want to take time to tell all that but—

MR: Okay. But you managed to keep playing?

EB: I wanted to get in the Air Force because I'd heard Glenn Miller had a band in Yale. So I joined the Air Cadets and it took me a month — he had to like get the okay for a college degree and stuff like that. And so I spent a month in, what was it Camp — no Fort Dix when I was drafted. I was drafted out of Woody's band by the way. Me and Nick Travis. And Bill Harris took my place.

MR: Oh my. I didn't know that.

EB: But anyway I had passed everything with the Air Cadets so they said, "what do you want to be, a bombardier or a navigator or a pilot?" I said, "no, I want to be a musician." "We don't have any musicians in the Air Cadets." "Oh really? Put me back in the Army." So they put me back in the Army. They said forget all that. So then they started Special Service at that point, so I was shipped down to Alabama. Camp Sibert. And people like Mickey Rooney and Joe Lewis were down there and all musicians and actors and stuff like that. So anyway one day one of the commanders came through and said "anybody got a band?" And Bill Finnegan was down there. He said, "yeah I've got a band." He knew all the guys you know. So he got a band together and we had one arrangement. They flew us down to Birmingham to play in the hospital for a dance. So we played one arrangement, you know, played the arrangement. Then we played some head arrangements. Then he said, "play the arrangement again." We played the arrangement again. So we got by on one arrangement. And they loved it. So they said they're going to put you on tour. So they made a tour. Meanwhile I got shipped out and I ended up, I'm not going to go through it all, but I ended up in several camps and then finally got back to Sibert. And Bill said, "where were you?" I said, "wherever they want me to go." So anyway he was going to Camp Shanks. So I ended up going with him. So we were in Camp Shanks, which is up near Nyack. So I was right near home, you know, across the river. So all we played was shows. It was an unauthorized band. We had a dog act, we had a comedian, and an 18 piece orchestra. And we played for Jo Stafford and Ethel Merman, who was pregnant. Anyway we played at the point of embarkation and just played troops in and out.

MR: Okay.

EB: So it was a good gig. So that was my Army career.

MR: Well at least you didn't have to go shoot a rifle then.

EB: No. Just for Basic Training.

MR. Was Chubby Jackson on the Woody Herman band when you were there?

EB: Yeah, he's the one that got me on because when I had the group with Shorty Rogers he was teaching the bass player. So Chubby got me on Woody's band. Well first he got me on Barnet's band. That was a great band at that point. And then he said the change is

coming and you've got to come in Woody's band. So I went in Woody's band and that's where I got drafted. So that was that. Then the Army. And then when I got out of the Army I went with Herbie Fields for a little bit. He was working around. I don't know if you know Herbie.

MR: Well you've got a succession of bands, kind of one after the other. Was there a particular reason that musicians seemed to go from one band to the other quite often?

EB: Yeah. In other words I'm from New York, right?

MR: Yeah.

EB: So you're based in New York. When Kai Winding left Stan Kenton, this was in '47, he called and said, "I'm not going back with the band so why don't you call Stan." Because he had seen me with Red when we were at The Aquarium in New York, you know a club in New York. He came in with his band. That was when that band debuted. And I was with Red at that time, with the small band. And he heard me and he was friendly and all that. So I wrote to him and he said yeah, come on the band. So that's California. So I had to go to California, right? I knew he was coming to New York because we worked at the Commodore Hotel for a month and then we went to the Paramount Theater and we did a lot of recording. This was in '47. So then he started back out to California. And meanwhile I had a baby with my wife and I said I've got to jump off. So I had to jump off. So that's what happened. I joined him three different times and I kept jumping off when he'd go back to California. Because, you know, the family situation. That's the way you stay married.

MR: Yeah.

EB: So anyway, that's why I was with a lot of bands. Because I'd always do that. When I went with Benny Goodman, he was going out, but he was going to stay out there for six months he told us. He stayed for six weeks and then started coming back. So that was kind of a drag.

MR: What was it like to be on the road at that time? Was it a tough life?

EB: Yeah. I mean you don't eat right and all that. Because you're traveling by bus mostly. And when you stop you stop. You're liable to stop in some place that don't have that good food and stuff like that. So it's kind of a scuffle.

MR: And a typical day, would the bus leave after you're done playing?

EB: It depends how far the trip is. If it's 300 miles or 500 miles, you've got to leave after the gig. And you had to pay for your own hotel in those days. So a lot of guys ghosted. In other words, you had two in a room instead of one. Or three. Whatever you can get away with.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Wow. And what was the salary like? I mean I know it varied from band to band.

EB: Yeah. From a bill and a half to two bills. But your expenses had to come out of that. So it wasn't like today. Today they put you up. It's different.

MR: I wanted to play a little piece here. See if it jogs your memory.

[audio interlude]

EB: Well I know it's Stan's band.

MR: Yeah.

EB: It's probably Maynard.

MR: "Cuban Carnival."

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: And you're on this, I think around '46 or so.

EB: No, it must have been '47.

MR: Okay.

EB: I joined him in '47.

MR: All right. '47. What did you think of his music?

EB: Well he featured trombones. That's why I wanted to go with that band. And he was very popular. I mean guys were poll winners in the band, like Shelly Manne and Art Pepper and all them. So I figured well let me go. Because Kai had done great on the band and Kai and I were friends. So I went with the band. And it was like a family that band. It was great. He was a great guy to work for. Great.

MR: Some people didn't think he swung very good.

EB: No. That he didn't.

MR: Okay.

EB: One night we played in Mankato, Minnesota. Mankato Ballroom. And generally Stan would like spread out. But this night the bandstand was small. So we were like this. And the band started swinging. And of course we all wanted to swing. So the band was swinging and he stopped it. He said, "this is not Basie. This is Stan Kenton." So we were looking at each other like damn. We finally got off the — you know—

MR: That's really curious.

EB: Yeah I don't know, he just didn't understand swinging.

MR: I never thought about it backwards though, I mean like at that point how would you stop swinging?

EB: I know. We all looked at each other like what is he talking about. I mean Shelly is a swinger. You know, Shelly Manne.

MR: Yeah. Don't swing.

EB: Well we always used to go out after the gig and go blow somewhere, wherever we were. But when you get on the bandstand it was Stan Kenton.

MR: Interesting. He did a lot of Latin oriented stuff too I guess at that time.

EB: Yeah. All kinds of stuff.

MR: But people who came to Kenton expecting to dance, was that a problem?

EB: We used to play the "Concerto to End All Concertos" and that was like all different tempos. And I swear I'd see people dancing. I don't know what they were doing but they were dancing. You know you'd have the crowd in the front they were all standing there, and then in the back would be people dancing. Well maybe they caught the changes, I don't know.

MR: Oh yow. Interesting.

EB: But his band was very popular, very.

MR: Yeah.

EB: He had like a machine. In other words, he had a guy that would go out a month in advance and set everything up, have pictures in all the music stores, have the records. It was his advance man. Then he would leave after the gig, wherever we were, he'd have his car, and he'd leave and do interviews and be on the radio in whatever city we were in, and it was like a machine. So it all kept rolling like that. It was very popular.

MR: Good self-promotion then.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: And Shelly Manne was on the group. Who were your section mates at the time, do you remember?

EB: That was Bart Varsalona, Milt Bernhart, Harry Betts, Harry Forbes and me. Five bones.

MR: Wow. That's a lot of people.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: A lot of payroll too.

EB: Well Pete Rugulo was writing most of the stuff and he wrote great.

MR: Yeah. I think that's one of his things.

EB: Very knowledgeable about the horns and how to write for them and all that. He's still writing.

MR: Was there any point in these years, late 40s or early 50s, did you ever think of changing careers?

EB: No I never thought of that.

MR: I'm glad.

EB: To what?

MR: Well okay. It was a little late for baseball I guess.

EB: But I had to figure out a way to get off the road because it was getting to be like I'd get in town and you'd try to get established and there was a lot of guys working and that — don't forget, every radio station had a band. And there was hotels, every hotel had a band. And there were theaters. That's all gone. There were a lot of clubs. I mean 52nd Street,

that was for a while, but then there was other clubs after that. And I mean guys were established in New York. And you'd come in and they'd say, "don't hire him he's a roadie." So I'd have to go back on the road. So my wife says, "why don't you use the GI bill?" So I went to Manhattan School of Music and it took me seven years to get a master's but meanwhile they heard I was in town so guys would call up and say can you do a date, like and I'd have to borrow a horn and run down and do a date. But finally I got in with the thing and I got established.

MR: I never heard that particular term before, "he's a roadie."

EB: Yeah well in other words you get a name that you're always on the road, which I was, but I couldn't do anything about it. Even though I was from New York, I couldn't get into that core. But eventually I did by going to school. Because when I went to Manhattan School of Music, Max Roach was there, John Lewis was there, Joe Wilder was there, and there was all, it was like a jazz school almost.

MR: But you weren't taking jazz courses, right?

EB: Oh no, no. They couldn't understand that.

MR: So you got a degree in teaching?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Right. Did you ever really use it?

EB: When I was doing my student teaching they had me go to Yonkers to do — a guy was doing jury duty, you know, the band whatever. So they said you go up there for two weeks. So I went up there and about the second or third day I went to the principal and I said, "I got a record date can I take off tomorrow?" He said, "what's a record date?" I said oh, Jesus, not for me. So I got out of that. I never used it.

MR: Oh that's funny, what's a record date.

EB: Yeah. If he didn't know what a record date was, I don't belong there. I had to get out. You can't turn record dates down. I mean then you end up a roadie.

MR: Okay. You're right back where you started.

EB: Yeah. So that was that. I forgot about the teaching.

MR: But you did get the degree.

EB: Yeah. I've still got it.

MR: Yeah you've still got it.

EB: My wife wants me to use it, I said no, you know, not now.

MR: That's great. Good story. So Benny Goodman, Ray McKinley, Les Elgart. It kind of goes on and on.

EB: Well you see in those days there was a lot of bands. A lot of bands. So you'd work from one to the other. Somebody'd always want you and the phone would ring and you'd do it.

MR: But you managed to kind of do them — how do I put this — and stay on the East Coast?

EB: Um hum.

MR: Okay. More than getting back on the bus.

EB: Oh yeah, sure. No I wanted to stay, you know, because I had two kids at that time.

MR: And you were able to kind of establish yourself and then get into the recording scene?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Broadway shows, all those kinds of things.

EB: Well the way I got into Broadway shows, I was working with Elliott Lawrence and things were bad for big bands and we were doing just weekends. And finally he said, "I'm going into the theater I'm going to take the band into the theater." So I said what did I want to do that for, because that was a schlock job in those days. I mean nobody wanted to play in the theater. It was like working in a submarine. But he said we were going to go in and we'd be able to take off and all that, which you weren't able to do in those days. But he established that and said you can take off.

MR: Oh. You'd just get a sub?

EB: Yeah. So anyway we started with "Bye Bye Birdie." And we did that for about a year, it was a big hit, and then he says, "we're going to change shows." I said, "what do you want to do that for?" It was a big hit. "No I'm going to change shows." I said, "what are you going to do?" He said, "well we've got this guy, Rudy Vallée and he threw out a bunch of names I never heard of, and I said, "what the heck's the name of the show?" He said, "How to Succeed in Business Without Really Trying." I said, "how are you going to fit it on the marquee?" But it was another hit.

MR: Rudy Vallée?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Was in the original?

EB: Yeah.

MR: I didn't know that.

EB: Bobby Morris, Charles Nelson Reilley, all those people. I didn't know who they were. I mean I knew Rudy Vallée. I said, "you want to work with Rudy Vallée?"

MR: What's he going to bring his megaphone?

EB: Yeah. No he did a whole line of shows. We worked with Steve and Edie, "The Golden Rainbow," we worked with Sammy Davis in "The Golden Boy," a whole bunch of shows. So that was great. Meanwhile we would take off so I was doing Thad Jones-Mel Lewis. You'd finish the show and you'd go down to The Vanguard and play.

MR: So this is early 60s then?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Oh that must have been great to do a show and then go play with Thad and Mel and let it all hang out.

EB: Yeah.

MR: I mean that was one of the greatest.

EB: Yeah.

MR: We'll get to that. I'm going to get to that. Because I wanted to ask you, you eventually hooked up again, I guess I'm going backwards now, with Bill Harris.

EB: That was '49. They've got a different date on there.

MR: Oh okay.

EB: It was '49. And we went to Chicago for three weeks. We had three trombones and rhythm. The rhythm was Shelly Manne, Bob Carter on bass and Lou Levy on piano. Bill Harris, me and Milty Gold. So we played for three weeks there. And then Mildred Bailey was supposed to join us and she was sick or something so there was a gap of like three or four weeks. And we were booked in Birdland. But everybody says man, what are we going to do for three or four weeks, just hang out? So everybody went with different bands.

MR: It definitely was a — you had to grab the opportunities when they came, didn't you?

EB: Yeah. Well I went back to New York after we did the three weeks in Chicago and there was Nola Studios, which was the place to meet. And everybody rehearsed there and so I rehearsed with the Nonet with Miles Davis for four times. It was a good group. I enjoyed it and all that. I came in one day and Kai Winding was there so I said ahh, see you later. So I went down the hall and auditioned for Benny Goodman and I went with the bebop band.

MR: Oh my.

EB: You know, with Wardell Gray and them. Because they were right in the same place, you know, Nola's. But you know Junior Collins that played with the Nonet? French horn?

MR: French horn. Yeah.

EB: About 20 years later I saw him on the street and he said, "hey I ever tell you what I told Miles you said?" I said, "no, what'd you tell him I said?" He said, "I told him you said the band was out of tune." So 20 years later you find out why you were replaced.

MR: Oh my.

EB: So I said, "what'd you do that for?" He said, "ahh it was getting boring."

MR: Jeez. And Benny was — was he making a conscious effort to maybe get a little more modern with that group?

EB: Maybe he was I don't know. I don't know where he had that idea. I mean he didn't fit in. But somehow he wanted to do that. Wardell was great.

MR: What was it like to work with Benny, or get along with him?

EB: Not like Stan. Well all the stories are true.

MR: Yeah they're all true?

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: Okay.

EB: Well he took us out to California and said we were going to be there six months. Guys subletted their apartments. I had a cheap apartment so I didn't sublet it. After six weeks he says, "I'm going to Lake Mead and I'm going fishing. And then we're going up and down the coast for about a week or two and then we're going back to New York." What about the six months? So guys jumped off. Milt Bernhart was on the band. He's from California so he just jumped off. Nick Travis drove back in a day and a half to Philadelphia, he got so mad. Straight through.

MR: Did you have your family with you?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Oh man.

EB: But it was lucky I didn't sublet my apartment, I could send them back.

MR: Did your kids have a sense of what you did for a living?

EB: Well they knew what I did, I don't know. Every time I'd go out they'd say, "have fun." I'd say, "what do you mean, I'm going to work." They still say that. Well I have fun but it's still, I don't want to let them know that.

MR: Good thinking. You want them to think that dad is working.

EB: Yeah. Somehow they knew.

MR: Right. You had your own, some Monday nights at Birdland.

EB: Well for a while I had my own group. In other words, when I was going to school, you know that Manhattan School of Music, I got a group together. I had Duke Jordan on piano all the time and Vinnie Dean on alto, a variety of drummers. I had a lot of different drummers. Osie Johnson, Gus Johnson, Eddie Shaughnessy, Joe Morello. And I worked Birdland and The Bohemia and we worked around Connecticut and around Jersey. So in fact I did an album called "Kaleidoscope" which hasn't been put out on CD, and that was that group. And it was — we had a lot of original material. I have some tapes that I did of that and which I'd like to get out too but so far I haven't gotten them out.

MR: Was there ever any issues about integrated bands at the time?

EB: No.

MR: Not in New York?

EB: No.

MR: That's good.

EB: No I always worked that way. It's what you play. It has nothing to do with the other thing. So I never got into that.

MR: Good. Tell me about, if you would, the Charles Mingus Jazz Workshop.

EB: Well I met Charles when I was with Benny Goodman the first time. We were in San Francisco and Clyde Lombardi, the bass player with Red, you know Red's small band, well we were with Benny at the time. Yeah it was Benny's band. Clyde was on Benny's band. And he said, "there's a bass player I want to hear down in the International Quarter." I said, "okay, I'll go with you." So we went. They had four basses and drums. Right? And Mingus is playing lead bass. So that's how I met him. And the next time I heard of him he had joined Red's trio in 1950 and they were going back to play The Embers. He had been in California. Tal Farlow and Mingus. So anyway Mingus got established in New York and he started this workshop. He and Teo Macero. And we used to rehearse quite a bit. And it was all original material. And eventually — I'm shortening it — Mingus got his own thing. I did an album with him at The Bohemia. It was me, George Barrow, Mal Waldron and Willie Jones. It was in '55. And Debut, eventually, I mean they put it out but it eventually got to Atlantic and went to a whole bunch of different albums. It was put out many times.

MR: Kind of piecemeal, or under different titles?

EB: Yeah. And eventually Fantasy put out an eleven CD album of all the Debut stuff. And it said, I had read a review and they said there was eleven tracks that were never issued of The Bohemia stuff. So I called Fantasy Records and I said, "can you send me a cassette of the eleven tracks?" "Oh no, we can't break up the — you know, you've got to buy the whole thing." So I said, "well I'm on it, can you do anything?" So they said, "well we'll give it to you for five dollars a CD." So I said okay. It came to sixty bucks. I wanted to hear some of the stuff from Debut anyway. So I got the thing, and I looked up what I made for the date. Sixty bucks.

MR: Ooh. Yeah.

EB: So I came out even.

MR: That's very interesting. Did he have a certain amount of — I should rephrase that — did he require some things from his sidemen that other leaders wouldn't?

EB: Well yeah. I mean he wanted you to play his music. And the way you played his music with a small group, he didn't write it out. You go up to his apartment and he'd play it for you on the piano, and you'd learn it in your head. And that's how you learned it. Because he said, "if I write it out you're going to play it different," which you do. If it's written out you play it different. But if you get it in your head and you play it like you want to play it. And he says, "play it your way." He didn't say any specific thing. Here it is. Like for instance "Jump Monk." When I first learned that, it was by rote. I just learned it. And when we went on The Bohemia, there was no music.

MR: No music.

EB: And he'd change things during the night, you know change little things. You'd be playing and he's singing in your ear, "play this," and he's singing. So you play it as he's singing it.

MR: Cool.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: You had to be on your toes.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: Gosh. Very interesting. Did they ever record, was it the Town Hall concert or something?

EB: Yeah. '62.

MR: Right.

EB: Yeah they recorded that. But what happened was they pushed the date up a month, which hung him up about writing the music. That's when he punched Jimmy Knepper in the mouth. And I asked Jimmy how did that happen. He said he was copying music for him and he went up to bring him some music and Mingus says, "write me something." So he says, "it's your concert, it's not my concert." Bamm. You know.

MR: I guess he was under a little pressure.

EB: Well yeah. But Jimmy didn't play the concert. He wasn't in the band. But he was doing the copying I guess.

MR: The concert was kind of a rough affair, wasn't it?

EB: Well we ended up, we were rehearsing while the audience was there. And then he went out and made this announcement, he said, "ladies and gentlemen this is a recording it's not a concert so if you want to get your money back go to the box office." And the producer's in the back saying what is he talking about? And half the audience left. But they had copyists copying the music while we were rehearsing it on the spot. And they were recording it. It ended up so like this — and then the stagehand said, "it's eleven o'clock and eleven o'clock we're pulling the curtain." So like that ended that. So like I don't know, either Clark Terry or Ernie Royal went [scats] and we started playing "Mellow Tone." And that was the last tune on the concert. And as I went off I had a plunger and I went [scats] and it's on the tape. I mean it was all like tension.

MR: Was Mingus even still on stage at that point?

EB: I don't know. I wanted to get out of there before they threw the tomatoes or something.

MR: Or something worse. Wow.

EB: It was a fiasco.

MR: You've got a history. I'm telling you, this is great.

EB: But they put the album out and it won an international critic's award. So figure that one out. And they had all the wrong titles. Nothing matched up. They called "Mellow Tone" "Sequence Two" or some weird title. I brought the music home because it was so hard, I

said I've got to study this. It was impossible. So I've still got some of it home, on onion skin.

MR: Do ya? Don't get rid of that.

EB: I tried to give it to Sue one day, she didn't want it. You know, when they did an epitath.

MR: You can give it to me.

EB: Yeah.

MR: Wow. Interesting. And then Thelonious Monk.

EB: Yeah.

MR: Wow.

EB: Well I think Hall Overton did a fantastic job writing that music because he caught the spirit. He got it right. He used to be playing piano, you know, when we were rehearsing, at Sixth Avenue around 28th Street on the second floor. There was a lot going on there. But he used to play the piano and Monk would be in the other room dancing. And he'd say, "but when are you going to play the piano?" He said, "when the tempo gets right." Yeah those rehearsals were something.

MR: Wow. You have worked with some characters.

EB: Yeah.

MR: Here's a piece I hope — whoops, I think I went the wrong way — from about that time. [audio interlude]

EB: Yeah that's Monk. Yeah.

MR: Now – that's good stuff. It's interesting when you say that Hall Overton caught the spirit. Because those [scats] those dissonances in there, would Monk have told him to do that?

EB: I have no idea what Monk told him. But whatever he did —because you can't write like what could I say — normal — you've got to write like Monk played it. And he don't play all the notes in the chord. You know he just plays specific notes. That's how he gets that sound. And you've got to know which ones to leave out. Otherwise it don't sound like Monk at all.

MR: What was it about the way you played that you were able to find your way into — I'm not asking this very well, but you've participated in what we now consider to be some important, historical situations.

EB: Yeah.

MR: And I'm wondering what was it about your playing or your personality or both that found your way into those things?

EB: I don't know. Something happened I guess. Lucky I guess.

MR: Lucky?

EB: Yeah.

MR: But you must have had a quick ear and ability to deal with those sometimes chaotic situations — it wasn't just reading the notes.

EB: Yeah well you have to adapt yourself to what's going on you know. I guess that's what it is. Because each band is different. It's not like that now. Everything is like one level, there's no waves. But in those days there was all kinds of stuff going on. I mean Mingus had his personality and Monk had his personality, Benny Goodman had his personality, Stan Kenton, Woody. I mean they were all different. So when you joined the band you had to fit in with that situation.

MR: What did you think of the bebop era when it came in, and was it called bebop at the time or maybe that was after the fact.

EB: Yeah I think the critics give boxes to things. It was an evolution, not a revolution. I mean it just happened. We used to go out and blow, and you'd be blowing like that, but when you come into the band you had to fit in with the band and you had to disregard a lot of that stuff. But eventually it came out with the small groups, you know, Charlie Parker and Dizzy and all them. Dizzy's band could do that and also Billy Eckstine's band. I mean they played that way, but not the general bands.

MR: What happened to the audience for the music during - oh gosh, mid 50s I guess.

EB: Well I guess it got to be concerts instead of dancing. The dancing is just starting to come back now, the last few years. But bands in the early days played for dancing. Even Duke and Basie and all them, I mean they played for dancing. But then it got to be concerts and the dances went another direction.

MR: Do you think that was a good or bad thing?

EB: It wasn't good. I'd much rather play for dancing. I like to see people dancing and enjoying themselves. I mean concerts are kind of a drag.

MR: So we've kind of made the music into a high art I guess.

EB: Yeah. Right. I mean I don't know if anybody understands that. It's like a language. bebop, so-called bebop, that's a language. It's a way of — we're talking to each other when we're playing. That's what it is.

MR: And talking fast sometimes.

EB: Yeah, right.

MR: Tell me a little bit more about recording with Thelonious Monk. Was it like other sessions you've done?

EB: No. But we had a lot of rehearsal. We rehearsed quite a bit. And just those concerts, he never did a tour with the band or anything like that. I've been touring with the Monk All-Stars lately, the last few years, Johnny Griffin and Phil Woods and Ben Riley. And Monk never did that. I think he went to Europe one time. I didn't go with him. Jimmy Cleveland went with him. But that's about the only time that he used that big band other than the

Lincoln Center and the Town Hall. I mean he did a Carnegie Hall but they never recorded that.

MR: Oh. Too bad.

EB: Yeah.

MR: And I see you're now working with his son on occasion?

EB: Yeah.

MR: That's great.

EB: Yeah we did a thing called "Monk on Monk" where he had about 25 people come in as stars, come in and write. And I was on that. In fact that CD, if you play it on a computer you get visuals.

MR: Oh. Great.

EB: Yeah. It was something new in those days, a couple of years ago — those days.

MR: Right. CD ROM I guess they call it.

EB: Something like that.

MR: Do you still get, I guess they call it residuals? Stuff from ASCAP? You don't get any — I don't know if it's the right word.

EB: Once in a while I get it for a tune.

MR: A tune.

EB: Yeah. But when they re-issue anything, you don't get anything. You know how many re-issues there are?

MR: Yeah.

EB: And it went through, like for me it went through 78s, EPs, LPs, now CDs. They're all different mediums. And we don't get paid for any of them.

MR: Wow. So some of those things have had several lives. Wow that's too bad.

EB: Oh yeah. One CD that I got paid extra for was "Mingus and His Friends." They put out two CDs. It came out originally on one LP. And the producer called me, Bob Belden. And he said, "how much did you rehearse?" Because he knows I keep track of all that. And I told him and there were extra tracks put out and I got a nice check.

MR: Excellent.

EB: That's about the only one though. Generally they don't even send you the album. I mean at least they could send you the album. I've got to go buy the album.

MR: That's low.

EB: Yeah I went to — some Elliott Lawrence thing came out and I went to one of these record stores and I said, "can I get any break, I'm on it, there's my name" I said, "I'm on it." "Oh we'll give you ten percent off." But I mean the record company can't send you an album?

MR: Wow. I see you played with Bob Rosengarden on Dick Cavett?

EB: Oh yeah. "The Dick Cavett Show." That was a great show. It wasn't like Johnny Carson it was more, well I learned a lot. They had people like Costeau and you know, all these people on it.

MR: Oh right.

EB: It was great. I mean you'd learn a lot.

MR: So you got to sit there and listen to what the —

EB: Not only did I sit there but I had a Bolex movie camera. And I asked Rosengarden when we started I said, "do you mind if I photograph?" He said, "if you're not playing, do what you want." So I'm sitting and I could see the stage and the stage is well lit, and I had a zoom. You know a Bolex was a great camera. I had a zoom I would zoom in and take all these photos of what was going on. So I got rehearsals, I got a lot of the in-person stuff.

MR: You still have all that?

EB: I've still got it but there's no sound. It's not like a video. There's no sound.

MR: It's like a silent movie.

EB: Yeah.

MR: I'll be darned.

EB: But I showed him the list one time. I showed Cavett the list. And he said, "well how am I going to have time to look at all that?" Because I've got I don't know how many feet. But now you can't get film and I can't get a projector to play them. My projector broke so I borrowed a projector and put it on video. But there was a lot of material there. I don't know. But you know what was funny was like Zero Mostel. He'd come up to the band and be doing all kinds of things and you could tell what he was saying by just looking at him. You didn't have to hear it. I mean he was like, oh man, he just projected. He was great.

MR: And you'd back up the musical guests too.

EB: Yeah. Well I have Mary Lou Williams, I have Erroll Garner, I have the Modern Jazz Quartet, I have Mingus and Miles and whoever was on you know. A lot of people were on. Duke was on. But there's no sound.

MR: Let me play one of my own personal —

EB: Can we take a break for a minute?

MR: Yes absolutely.

[pause]

MR: Okay I'm going to start all over here. I want to play this little piece for you.

[audio interlude]

MR: Tell me, the first time you saw that, I mean it sounds hard to me.

EB: I saw that on the date.

MR: You saw that on the date? On that date? For "Consummation?"

EB: Yeah. How would you like to walk in the studio and get that thrown at you?

MR: Wow. That's fantastic.

EB: Yeah. That is ruthless.

MR: That's a great album.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: I mean it's one of the best. So you'd get a run through? Let's run this down?

EB: Well a couple of run throughs, yeah.

MR: A couple of run throughs.

EB: Because that was the trombones and the bass together.

MR: Boy. And a mistake would just stand out a little bit, right?

EB: I know, yeah. Yeah it was rough because the positions are like all over the place.

MR: You've toured overseas some?

EB: Yeah.

MR: You went to, was it Russia with the Louis Armstrong—

EB: Oh yeah. For a month. I went through with Dick Hyman.

MR: What was it like playing in Russia?

EB: They loved it.

MR: Yeah?

EB: Yeah. Great. It was a great band. With that band you get the feeling like when you go on the road with a band and you get tight. That only happens on the road. And that month it happened. It was great. But it doesn't happen too much anymore.

MR: It seems to be that it's really hard, whether from economics or whatever, for people to have bands.

EB: I know.

MR: To keep anybody together, to gel.

EB: Yeah, right. Yeah it doesn't happen too often anymore. I'm working with a band now, George Gee, and it's been together for about fifteen years. I mean it's spasmodic, you know, working here and there. But we went to Zurich and worked this past summer. And it was great.

MR: What's the fellow's name?

EB: George Gee. Yeah he plays for swing dancing a lot. But it's a good band. In fact the first night in Zurich we played in the train station and the other band was Basie. So Basie's band and George Gee.

MR: Wow. Like the old Savoy days, huh?

EB: Yeah. It was great.

MR: Cool. Tell me about, you've written a few tunes too in your life. And they've been, most of them inspired by particular things?

EB: Different things, yeah.

MR: Yeah? Like what?

EB: Well when I was going to school I used to ride the subway and you'd hear the click clack and all that, so I wrote a thing called "Little Train." Things like that. But in fact I have an album I'll give you that I made with just bass and most of the tunes that I wrote are on it, and Don Sickler, who is a publisher, put out a lead sheet book, so you can have that if you want.

MR: Excellent. When you did your tunes, your recordings, back in the 50s, if you had put your own tune on it, you'd get a little extra money?

EB: Naa. Once in a while I see, like I get a check with a whole bunch of countries listed, and a check for like $4.95 or something. BMI.

MR: I see.

EB: But I guess I'm lucky to get anything. So they're still playing them somewhere.

MR: What's your view on the music scene these days?

EB: Well you've just got to try to make a living nowadays. It's kind of rough. Not like before when there was that many bands and things were happening. You don't even see people in New York. There used to be — we used to get places to meet and all that, and that doesn't happen anymore.

MR: What was your — if you look back on your career, was there a series of years that you, in retrospect would say, that's when I was the busiest or that's when I was really enjoying myself the most?

EB: Well as far as putting albums out, I had seven albums out in the 50s. It was a great time. But I didn't follow it up because of the family. You know you'd have to go on the road and stay on the road and all that, so I didn't want to do that. I just stayed in New York and did recordings and jingles and things like that, which was a good living.

MR: When you would go to do a jingle date, you don't know what to expect when you walk in to those things, right? You sit down and use your reading skills?

EB: Yeah.

MR: Sometimes you might not even know what the product is?

EB: No. It's all — do it then. But it works. You get used to it.

MR: And is this pretty much stuff that's done through the union?

EB: No. The union doesn't have anything to do with it. It's your connections. The union just collects their work dues.

MR: Oh gosh. What's in the near future for you? I know you're doing Bobby Short.

EB: Yeah well it's just day to day. I do what I can. A lot of rehearsal bands and stuff to keep chops. But that's what you have to do, and then do a lot of traveling. You know last Friday I worked in Morristown, New Jersey and that's like 100 miles each way. And

what was it yesterday, no day before yesterday I worked in Lambertville, which is outside of New Hope. That was 150 miles each way. And then I make some rehearsal bands, I do a rehearsal in Emerson, New Jersey, that's 65 miles each way. That's no pay. That's a rehearsal. Then I rehearse with another band in Berlin, Connecticut, and that's 45 miles each way.

MR: Looks like you've got your mileage down anyway.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: Well looking at this list of bands and I'm trying to think of someone you haven't played with. Is there somebody that you wish you had played with?

EB: Yeah, Duke. I had three chances to go with him. The first one was when Oscar Pettiford was in the band and I had worked with Oscar on Charlie Barnet's band. He had two basses believe it or not, Chubby Jackson and Oscar. And that didn't last too long because Chubby one day came to Oscar and said, "we're going down front with our basses and we're going to do a dance." So Oscar says, "I'm a bass player, bye." And he split.

MR: I could see Chubby doing that but probably not Oscar.

EB: Yeah. But anyway he wanted to get me on the band, but that was in 1952 and I was trying to get established in New York and I couldn't do that. Too bad. And another time, like I said, I was using Duke Jordan on piano and one of my daughters in the morning she said to me, "somebody, Duke called you and wanted to know something." So I said, "well I don't have any work right now," you know, for Duke. She said, "no, not that Duke, the Duke you have all the records of." I said, "you mean Duke Ellington?" She says, "yeah." He wanted me to go to the Howard Theater in Washington. Evidently Lawrence Brown had gotten sick. But it was already too late. You know it was the morning. And then the next time his sister called, Ruth, and said, "Duke wants you to do the Far East and Australia" and all that. So I said I just got called for the Dick Cavett Show. So when he came to do "The Dick Cavett Show" with Mercer and Cootie, he was on the show, and I knew he was coming and I had gone to a stamp guy that I dealt with and they had put out "Toga." They put two stamps of his out. One was purple and one was green. I told the stamp guy if he can ever get sheets of them, you know. About three months later I walk in the store and he says, "I got the sheets." I said, "what sheets?" He said, "Duke Ellington." "What?" So I got two sheets. So I brought them to the show. And I said "hey, would you sign them things for me?" He said, "would you speak out, I can use the publicity." So he signed the sheets. And then he said, "we missed you." And I said well you see what I've got to do, and he said yeah, I know what you've got to do. I mean that was four years work with Dick Cavett, right in town. But I still would have liked to have gone with the band.

MR: Right. What did you do for things like retirement and health insurance and all those things all those years?

EB: When you're working in the theater you're covered for health insurance. I never used it. Now I've got to pay. It's over four hundred dollars for my wife and I each, per quarter. I don't even want to get into that.

MR: I know. It's a sticky—

EB: And then you go to a doctor, like my wife has been going to a doctor, and they say, "oh yeah, you're covered." And then all of a sudden you start getting bills. And you call and say how come I'm paying all that money and where is it going? But then when you're doing the theater, in other words, when you're working you're covered. When you don't work you're not covered. It's kind of backwards. No?

MR: It's true.

EB: Well the union is backwards. But that's the way it is.

MR: Yeah. You've worked also with a couple of good practical jokers: Bill Harris.

EB: Oh yeah.

MR: Did he ever pull anything on ya?

EB: Well I went back with Woody in '50. And he was on the band. This was after we had that three trombone thing in '49. And I roomed with him. So one night I get up and he's walking around with the headphones and he's doing — on everything. So I said, "hey Bill, it's like three o'clock in the morning, what are you doing?" He said, "put the headphones on." So I put the headphones on. He goes [scats] that's what he was doing. But he'd do all kinds of things.

MR: Really. What tune was it — sing that tune again.

EB: "Third Man Theme."

MR: Oh "Third Man Theme." Wow.

EB: It was something. He was a lot of fun.

MR: Him and Chubby. A lot of energy.

EB: Yeah.

MR: Well this has been marvelous talking to you. I don't know if there's something that you'd like to talk about that I haven't asked.

EB: Well you asked quite a bit of stuff. I can't think of anything off hand.

MR: I'm glad you didn't become a baseball catcher.

EB: Yeah, me too. After I heard Lester, that did it.

MR: That's really interesting too that you happened to hit upon that first recording.

EB: I know it. And I had no idea who it was because Jones-Smith, that doesn't tell you anything. But I found out.

MR: Wow. Well I'm glad you played the trombone instead of the tenor sax, because you've played with so many great people. Best of luck and keep doing it.

EB: Well you know I bought a tenor just to see what "Blue and Sentimental" would feel like playing. And this guy that has a music store in New Haven, Sol Libro, he called me for a gig and he says, "you'll never find it, you better meet me at the store." So I said okay I'll show up early. So I brought the tenor and I brought it in the store. And he says, "what's that?" I said, "my tenor." He says, "I thought you played trombone?" So I said "really?"

MR: You put him on.

EB: So he'd had a heart attack recently so I said wait a minute, I just wanted you to evaluate the horn.

MR: Don't give him another one. Good story. Well listen thanks so much for your time today.

EB: Thank you.

MR: It's been a great pleasure meeting you.

EB: Thank you.

MR: Thanks for bringing your material here.